

OCEANS AND CONTINENTS

Ocean water never gets as hot or cold as the land, because it gains and loses heat so slowly. This affects the climate on islands and coastal regions, making it milder than the climate at the heart of a continent. So even in summer, people living on an island never get as hot as people living in the middle of a nearby continent, and they never get as cold in winter either.

▼ MARITIME CLIMATE

The surrounding Pacific Ocean gives the islands of New Zealand a mild, moist climate.



▲ HUMPBACK WHALE

These whales communicate by “singing” to each other. This consists of a sequence of howls, moans, and cries, which can last for hours.

SPEEDY SOUND

The speed of sound in water is more than four times faster than the speed of sound in air. This enables marine animals such as whales to call to each other over incredible distances. In some parts of the ocean, sound transmission is so efficient that a whale call generated on one side of an ocean can be picked up on the other side, up to 15,500 miles (25,000 km) away.



DEADLY SOUND

The speed of sound in water allows animals such as this remarkable little pistol shrimp to use it as a weapon. The shrimp has a specialized claw that it can lock open. When prey comes close, the shrimp snaps the claw shut with a pistol-shot noise loud enough to kill its victim. For a split second it is one of the loudest sounds in the ocean.

WOW!

Sound waves travel faster underwater than they do in air, and the deeper you go, the faster they travel.

